Please check the examination details below before entering your candidate information

Candidate surname | Other names

Centre Number | Candidate Number

Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9-1)

Thursday 4 June 2026

Morning (Time: 1 hour 50 minutes - total time for **both** booklets)

History

BOOKLET B4: Early Elizabethan England, 1558-88

Paper reference

1HI0/B4 (Paper 2)

You must have:
The corresponding booklet P.

Total Marks

Instructions

- Use **black** ink or ball-point pen.
- **Fill in the boxes** at the top of this page with your name, centre number and candidate number.
- There are two booklets in this question paper. **This is booklet B.**
- Answer questions 1(a), 1(b), 2 and **either 3 or 4** in this booklet.
- Check you have the corresponding booklet P.
- Answer the questions in the spaces provided
  - there may be more space than you need.

Information

- The total mark for this booklet is 32.
- The total time for **both** booklets is 1 hour 50 minutes.
- The marks for **each** question are shown in brackets
  - use this as a guide as to how much time to spend on each question.
- **Do not forget to complete booklet P.**

Advice

- Read each question carefully before you start to answer it.

- Try to divide your time equally between each booklet of the question paper.
- Check your answers if you have time at the end.

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Early Elizabethan England, 1558-88

Answer Question 1(a), Question 1(b), Question 2 and EITHER Question 3 OR Question 4.

1 (a) Describe one feature of Elizabethan England in 1558: society and government. (2)

Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:
One feature of society was its rigid, hierarchical structure known as the "Great Chain of Being". At the top was the monarch, followed by the nobility and gentry, while the vast majority at the bottom were landless labourers, with everyone expected to accept their fixed place in God's ordered universe.

(b) Describe one feature of Drake and the raid on Cadiz: 'Singeing the King of Spain's beard'. (2)

Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:
One feature was the devastating destruction of Spanish naval shipping and supplies. Drake sailed directly into Cadiz harbour in 1587 and destroyed approximately 30 Spanish ships and thousands of seasoned wooden barrel staves, which successfully delayed the launch of the Spanish Armada by a full year.

(Total for Question 1 = 4 marks)

2 Explain why Elizabeth faced challenges at home and from abroad upon her accession in 1558.

(12)

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- financial weaknesses
- the French threat

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

Teacher Mark Scheme Model Answer:

Upon her accession in 1558, Elizabeth faced immediate **financial weaknesses** that severely threatened her survival. Her predecessor, Mary I, had left the crown deeply in debt, with a deficit of approximately £300,000. This was a crippling weakness because, in the 16th century, a monarch had to "live of their own" and pay for all administration and defence. This financial crisis meant Elizabeth could not afford to raise an army to defend her borders or pay off the high-interest loans (often 14%) owed to foreign bankers. Her lack of money made her look weak and encouraged both domestic rebels and foreign rivals to believe she could easily be overthrown, as she lacked the funds to defend her crown.

Secondly, the **French threat** from abroad was a major challenge for the young queen. France was a powerful Catholic nation and England's traditional enemy. Since Mary I's reign, England had been involved in a disastrous war alongside Spain against France, which had resulted in the humiliating loss of Calais, England's last foothold in Europe. Furthermore, France had secured a strong presence in Scotland through the 'Auld Alliance'. French troops were stationed on the northern border under Mary of Guise (mother of Mary, Queen of Scots). Elizabeth faced the terrifying prospect of a two-pronged Catholic invasion from France and Scotland, designed to depose her and replace her with Mary Stuart.

Finally, Elizabeth's challenge at home was compounded by the intense **problem of her legitimacy and gender**. Many English Catholics did not believe Elizabeth was the rightful queen. They did not recognise Henry VIII's divorce from his first wife, Catherine of Aragon, meaning they viewed Henry's marriage to Elizabeth's mother, Anne Boleyn, as illegal and Elizabeth as illegitimate. Additionally, 16th-century society was highly patriarchal; female rulers were viewed as weak and unnatural, incapable of leading armies into battle. This prejudice created political instability, as her Privy Council immediately pressured her to marry to secure the succession, while her gender encouraged Catholic plotters to conspire against her from the very start of her reign.

(Total for Question 2 = 12 marks)

Turn over ▶

Answer EITHER Question 3 OR Question 4.

EITHER

3 **'Mary, Queen of Scots: her claim to the English throne was the main cause of the Revolt of the Northern Earls, 1569–70.'**

How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- religious divisions
- the role of the nobility

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

(Total for Question 3 = 16 marks)

OR

4 **'The actions of Robert Dudley were the main reason for deteriorating relations with Spain in the years 1585–88.'**

How far do you agree? Explain your answer.

*You **may** use the following in your answer:*

- English direct involvement in the Netherlands
- commercial rivalry

*You **must** also use information of your own.*

(Total for Question 4 = 16 marks)

Indicate which question you are answering by marking a cross in the box ☒. If you change your mind, put a line through the box ☒ and then indicate your new question with a cross ☒.

Chosen question number: Question 3 ☐ Question 4 ☐

Teacher Mark Scheme (Question 3):

The Revolt of the Northern Earls in 1569 was the first major domestic rebellion Elizabeth faced. While **Mary, Queen of Scots and her claim to the English throne** provided the vital Catholic alternative that made the rebellion possible, the revolt was actually caused by a combination of deep-rooted **religious divisions** and the northern nobility's anger at losing their traditional political power to Elizabeth's southern Protestant ministers.

On the one hand, Mary Stuart's presence in England and her claim to the throne were central to the rebellion. When Mary fled Scotland and arrived in England in 1568, she became a natural focal point for Catholic hopes. The northern rebels, led by Thomas Percy (Earl of Northumberland) and Charles Neville (Earl of Westmorland), hatched a plan to marry Mary to Thomas Howard, the Duke of Norfolk (the premier Protestant noble in England). They believed that marrying Mary to Norfolk would secure her succession to the English throne, depose Elizabeth, and restore Catholicism. Mary's royal blood and legitimate Tudor lineage provided the essential mechanism through which the northern earls hoped to legitimise their treasonous actions.

On the other hand, **religious divisions** were a more powerful motivator for the ordinary rebels who joined the uprising. The north of England had remained stubbornly Catholic despite Elizabeth's 1559 Religious Settlement. Many northern Catholics resented Elizabeth's Protestant laws and the removal of traditional Catholic practices. When the earls raised their standard in rebellion, their first public act was to march into Durham Cathedral, tear down the Protestant communion table, and hold a traditional Catholic Latin Mass. For the 4,600 ordinary soldiers who joined the rebel army, the revolt was a holy crusade to defend the Catholic faith against what they viewed as a heretical Protestant government in London.

Furthermore, the revolt was heavily fueled by the grievances of **the northern nobility** regarding their loss of political power. Historically, the northern earls had ruled their lands like semi-independent monarchs, controlling local government and border defence. However, Elizabeth was determined to centralise her power. She systematically ignored the traditional Catholic nobility, appointing her own loyal, southern Protestant lords (such as James Pilkington as Bishop of Durham) to run northern affairs. Northumberland had been stripped of his lucrative role as Warden of the Middle Marches and lost custody of a valuable copper mine on his land. The rebellion was, therefore, a desperate attempt by the traditional nobility to reclaim their feudal rights and political influence from Elizabeth's upstart southern advisors, such as William Cecil.

In conclusion, I partially agree with the statement. Mary, Queen of Scots' claim to the throne was the indispensable *catalyst* for the rebellion because she represented the only viable Catholic successor to Elizabeth. However, the *primary* causes of the revolt were religious and political: the deep-rooted Catholic faith of the northern population, combined with the northern nobility's fury at being stripped of their traditional regional power by a centralising Protestant government. Without these deeper regional grievances, the earls would never have taken the immense risk of rising in rebellion.

Teacher Mark Scheme (Question 4):
The outbreak of war between England and Spain in 1585 was the culmination of years of growing hostility. While **the actions of Robert Dudley** in the Netherlands deeply insulted King Philip II and worsened the diplomatic crisis, the primary cause of the war was the geopolitical reality of **English direct involvement in the Netherlands**, which was driven by religious solidarity and a long-standing **commercial rivalry** across the Atlantic.

On the one hand, Robert Dudley's actions in the Netherlands significantly escalated tensions between 1585 and 1588. When Elizabeth sent Dudley (the Earl of Leicester) to the Netherlands in command of English troops, she instructed him to act cautiously and only defend the Dutch Protestant rebels. However, Dudley ignored her orders. In January 1586, he accepted the title of "Governor-General of the Low Countries" from the Dutch rebels. This was a catastrophic diplomatic blunder because it implied that Elizabeth was claiming sovereignty over territory that belonged to King Philip II. It infuriated Philip, convinced him that Elizabeth aimed to steal his empire, and made him commit fully to launching the Spanish Armada to overthrow her.

On the other hand, the deeper cause of the conflict was **English direct involvement in the Netherlands** through the signing of the Treaty of Nonsuch in 1585. Elizabeth had spent decades trying to avoid war with Spain, but when the Dutch Protestant rebel leader, William of Orange, was assassinated in 1584, the Dutch rebellion was on the verge of collapsing. If Spain crushed the Dutch, Philip II would control the entire English Channel coastline, providing Spain with a perfect launching pad for an invasion of England. Elizabeth was forced to sign the Treaty of Nonsuch, committing 7,000 English troops to actively fight the Spanish army under the Duke of Parma. This direct military intervention was essentially an open declaration of war, making the Armada conflict inevitable regardless of Dudley's subsequent mistakes.

Furthermore, **commercial rivalry** in the New World had been poisoning Anglo-Spanish relations for decades. Under Spanish law, English merchants were forbidden from trading with Spain's wealthy colonies in the Americas. English privateers, most notably Sir Francis Drake and Sir John Hawkins, systematically ignored this ban. Drake spent the 1570s and 1580s raiding Spanish treasure ships and colonies, famously stealing £400,000 of Spanish silver during his circumnavigation. Instead of punishing Drake, Elizabeth knighted him on the deck of the *Golden Hind* in 1580. This state-sponsored piracy humiliated Philip II and hit Spain financially, causing Philip to conclude that he could only protect his treasure fleets by conquering England.

Finally, **religious rivalry** acted as the underlying ideological foundation of the

conflict. Philip II viewed himself as the global leader of the Counter-Reformation, dedicated to wiping out Protestantism across Europe. He viewed Elizabeth as a heretic who had illegally deposed Catholic authority. Philip had spent years supporting Catholic plots to assassinate Elizabeth (such as the Throckmorton Plot in 1583) and had signed the Treaty of Joinville with France in 1584 to create an anti-Protestant alliance. This religious crusade meant that Philip viewed war with England not just as a political dispute, but as a religious duty.

In conclusion, I disagree with the statement. Robert Dudley's actions were a significant diplomatic embarrassment that accelerated the timeline of the Spanish invasion. However, the *true* cause of the outbreak of war was Elizabeth's decision to sign the Treaty of Nonsuch and commit to **direct military involvement in the Netherlands**. This strategic decision, combined with decades of bitter **commercial rivalry** and state-sponsored piracy by Drake, made a military showdown with Spain entirely unavoidable.

TOTAL FOR BOOKLET B = 32 MARKS

PLEASE ENSURE YOU ALSO COMPLETE BOOKLET P.

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